

HandBound Rulebook

This is the master rules document for the HandBound trading card game.

Overview

HandBound is a fast-paced two-player trading card game where your hand is everything: it holds the cards you can play, the resources you spend, and it represents your life total.

Every time you play a card or pay a cost, you discard cards from your hand, bringing you closer to defeat. The tension comes from balancing powerful plays with the risk of running low on cards, since running out means you lose the game.

The duel continues until one player is left with no cards in hand. Games are dynamic, strategic, and typically last 10 to 25 minutes.

Objective

The primary objective is to reduce the opponent's hand to 0 cards. If a player has 0 cards in hand at any time, that player loses the game. If both players would have 0 cards in hand simultaneously, the game ends in a draw.

Cards

In HandBound, cards fall into two broad groups: cards you can play, and cards you cannot play. Playable cards are your creatures and spells. Nonplayable Cards are still part of your deck and hand, but they exist mainly to support HandBound's hand-based resource system.

Basics of a Playable Card

When you look at a card, these are the most important things to identify first:

Name — what the card is called.

Cost — how many cards you must discard from your hand to play the card.

Rarity — the higher the rarity, the more powerful and rarer the card is.

Rarities: Legendary, Epic, Rare, Uncommon, Common.

Type — one or two archetypes, such as **Bug**, **Beast**, **Light**, or **Dark**, that the card belongs to.

Number — all cards have a unique number (XXXXXX-X).

First digit determines creature or spell, second is the card rarity, and the last 4 digits are for the card itself. The number after the dash is for the card art.

Flavor Text — this is small text at the bottom of the card that adds some lore or other interesting tidbits about the card. These have no effect on the game.

Creature Cards

Creature cards are the cards that stay on the field and battle, and are the main way you engage with battles.

A **Creature** card is a **permanent**. A permanent is a card that remains on the field after it is played.

When a creature is played, it enters its controller's **Field**.

A creature remains on the field until it is destroyed, discarded, exiled, or moved to another zone by an effect.

A creature card has **ATK** and **DEF**.

ATK is the amount of damage that the creature deals in battle or when an effect instructs it to deal damage.

DEF is the amount of damage required in a single battle to destroy that creature.

A creature card may also have **abilities**; these abilities are special effects that the creature has.

Abilities **MUST** be followed exactly how they are printed.

A creature's ability may state when it can be used: follow that timing.

If a creature's ability does not state a different timing, it can be used only during its controller's **Main Phase**.

Example: an "At the start of your turn" ability must be done at the start of your turn.

A "Once per turn" ability must be activated by you and done during the Main Phase.

A creature can attack on the turn it is played.

Spell Cards

Spell cards create one-time effects.

A Spell card is *not* a permanent.

Spell cards have effects that must be followed.

A spell resolves once, after it is played.

After a spell resolves, it goes to its owner's Discard Pile.

Spell cards do not have ATK or DEF.

A spell card might be clearly labeled as an "At Will" card.

A spell labeled **At Will** may be played outside of the Main Phase, usually whenever its printed timing allows. If there is no printed timing, an At Will may be played at any time during the game.

Playing Cards

To play a card: pay its cost by discarding cards from your Hand equal to its cost, and declare it. The card is considered to now be played. Next, if the card is a creature, "on play" abilities would now take effect; if the card is a spell, the spell's effect would activate, and then the spell would resolve.

Most cards are played during your Main Phase.

A player may play **Creature** cards and **Spell** cards only during that player's **Main Phase** and only from their hand.

A spell labeled **At Will** may be played outside of the Main Phase, usually whenever its printed timing allows. If there is no printed timing, an At Will may be played at any time during the game.

Nonplayable Cards

Nonplayable Cards are clearly labeled as Nonplayable and are included in decks but are not played as Creatures or Spells.

A **Nonplayable Card** is not a playable card.

A **Nonplayable Card** cannot be played.

A Nonplayable Card may be drawn, held in hand, discarded to pay costs, discarded by damage or effects, shuffled into a deck, or moved by effects that refer to cards generally.

If an effect refers specifically to a Creature card or Spell card, a Nonplayable Card is not a legal choice.

Game Zones

Every card in HandBound is always somewhere in the game. That "somewhere" is called a **zone**.

Zones help players understand three things:

where a card currently is, who is allowed to view it, and what it is allowed to do.

Most cards will move between the **Deck**, **Hand**, **Field**, and **Discard Pile** during a game. Some cards may also be put into **Exile**. During an attack, creatures involved in that attack temporarily enter **Battle** before the attack finishes.

As a quick rule of thumb:

Deck and **Hand** are hidden zones.

Field, **Battle**, **Discard Pile**, and **Exile** are public zones.

General Zone Rules

A **zone** is a defined game area that can contain cards.

Zones are usually independent, but can be in other zones (your field is in the field), so cards are considered in both zones.

If a card moves from one zone to another, it leaves its previous zone and enters the new zone.

If a card is discarded to pay a cost, it moves from the Hand to the Discard Pile and is not considered to have been played.

Cards in public zones are face up.

Cards in hidden zones are face down and cannot be looked through. (except for your hand)

A card's **owner** is the player whose deck the card began the game in. A card's owner never changes throughout a game.

A card's **controller** is the player currently allowed to use that card; all cards in a player's individual field are controlled by that player.

Zones

1. Deck

The **Deck** is a player's draw pile.

Each player begins the game with their own constructed Deck.

A player's Deck is a hidden zone.

Cards in a Deck are kept face down.

Players may look at the number of cards remaining in any Deck.

When a player draws a card, they move the top card of their Deck into their Hand.

2. Hand

The **Hand** is the group of cards a player is currently holding.

A player's Hand is a hidden zone for everyone but the player. (Players are allowed to look at their own hand)

Players may know how many cards are in each player's Hand.

A player plays cards from their Hand.

A player pays a card's cost by discarding cards from their Hand as described by the rules for playing cards.

A player's Hand also functions as that player's life total. If a player ever has 0 cards in hand, that player loses the game.

3. The Field

The **Field** is the main play area for creatures.

The Field is a public zone.

There is no limit to the number of creatures that may be on a Field.

A creature on the Field remains there until it moves to another zone.

a. Your Field

Your field is the main play area for your creatures

This field is inside of The Field.

Your Field is the part of the Field that holds creatures you control.

When a creature is played by you, it enters your field.

b. Opponents Field

Your opponent's field is the main play area for your opponent's creatures

This field is inside of The Field.

Your opponent's field is the part of the field that holds creatures your opponent controls.

When a creature is played by your opponent, it enters your opponent's field.

6. Battle Zone

A **Battle Zone** is a temporary zone used during an attack. The Battle Zone is a conceptual zone used to track creatures involved in an attack. Cards do not need to be physically moved.

A Battle Zone is a public zone.

When an attack reaches the Battle Step, each attacking creature in that attack and the attack's target enter a Battle Zone for that attack.

A creature in a Battle Zone keeps the same controller it had on the Field.

When the attack resolves, all creatures leave the Battle Zone.

A creature that leaves a Battle Zone returns to the same Field it came from unless it was destroyed or moved to a different zone during its time in the Battle Zone.

7. Discard Pile

The **Discard Pile** is where used and destroyed cards go.

Each player has their own Discard Pile.

A Discard Pile is a public zone.

Discarded cards are put into their owner's Discard Pile.

Destroyed creatures are put into their owner's Discard Pile.

After a spell resolves, it is put into its owner's Discard Pile.

Either player may inspect any Discard Pile at any time.

8. Exile

Exile is the zone for cards that have been removed from normal play.

Exile is a public zone.

Exiled cards are not in the Deck, Hand, Field, Battle, or Discard Pile.

Exiled cards cannot return to another zone or be used in the current game.

Game Setup (Deck Construction)

Before a game of HandBound begins, each player brings a deck that was built in advance. A legal deck must follow the game's deck-building rules, including card counts, Type restrictions, Rarity limits, and maximum number of copies.

After both players are ready, they shuffle their decks, draw their opening hands, and may take a one-time mulligan if they do not want to keep those cards. Once setup is complete, the first player is chosen (typically the winner of rock, paper, scissors), and the game begins.

Legal Deck Requirements

A player's deck must contain exactly 40 cards.

Each deck must contain exactly 25 playable cards and exactly 15 Nonplayable cards.

All playable cards in a deck must share a single Type chosen by that deck's owner.

A deck must not contain more than 2 cards with the same name.

A deck must follow the rarity limits for playable cards listed below.

Rarity Limits (Playable Cards Only)

Each deck has the following rarity slots:

Legendary: 1

Epic: 2

Rare: 4

Uncommon: 7

Common: 11

Rarity slots must be filled by a card of the same or lower rarity.

Example: A deck may include 12 Common cards, 6 Uncommon cards, 4 Rare cards, and 3 Epic cards by using its 1 Legendary slot on an Epic card, and one of its Uncommon slots on a Common card.

Starting the Game

Each player shuffles their deck.

Each player presents their deck to the opponent to cut.

Each player draws 3 cards.

After drawing their opening hand, each player decides whether to keep their hand or take a mulligan.

To take a mulligan, a player shuffles their entire hand into their deck, presents that deck to the opponent to cut, then draws 3 new cards.

A player may only take additional mulligans if their opening hand is three Nonplayable Cards.

Determine which player goes first by rock, paper, scissors, die rolls, or any other agreed-upon method.

The player going first then begins the game with their Start Step

Turn Structure

Each turn consists of the following steps and phases, in order:

Start Step

Draw Phase

Attack Phase

Main Phase

End Step

The player whose turn it is is called the **active player**. The other player is the **non-active player**.

Players continue alternating turns until one player loses the game.

Step and Phase Rules

1. Start Step

The active player's turn begins with the Start Step.

Abilities or effects that say at the start of a player's turn trigger during this step.

If multiple effects are set to resolve at the same time, use the timing order described in the Miscellaneous Rules section.

2. Draw Phase

The active player draws 2 cards from the top of their deck to their hand.

3. Attack Phase

During the Attack Phase, the active player may declare any number of attacks, including none.

A creature can attack only once per Attack Phase.

Attacks are declared and resolved one at a time. After one attack fully resolves, the active player may declare another attack with a creature(s) that has not yet attacked this phase.

Detailed rules for attacking and battles are found in the **Attacking and Battles** section.

4. Main Phase

The active player may play any number of legal cards from their hand.

To play a card, the player discards cards from their hand equal to that card's cost. The card being played does not count toward its own discard cost.

The active player may activate creature abilities, such as once-per-turn abilities, during the main phase.

5. End Step

Abilities and effects that say they trigger at the end of the active player's turn trigger during this step.

Then, the next player's turn begins with that player's Start Step.

Attacking and Battles

Attacking is the main way creatures affect the game of HandBound. During your **Attack Phase**, you may send your creatures into battles to destroy opposing creatures or your opponent.

Each attack uses one or more of your creatures and exactly one target. Most attacks target a creature on the opponent's field. If the opponent has no creatures on their field when you declare the attack, you may target that opponent's hand instead. This is called a **direct attack**.

General Attack Rules

During your **Attack Phase**, you may declare any number of attacks, one at a time, or declare no attacks.

To declare an attack, declare one or more creatures you control that have not attacked during this **Attack Phase** to be **Attackers**.

A creature cannot be part of more than one attack during the same **Attack Phase**.

Each attack has exactly one target.

When you declare an attack, choose one **legal target** for that attack:

- a single creature on the opponent's field, or
- the opponent's hand, provided there are no other legal targets.

This is called a **Direct Attack**.

A creature declared as part of an attack is an **attacking creature** for that attack.

Once a creature has been declared as an attacking creature, it is considered to have attacked during that **Attack Phase**, even if its target leaves the field later or the attack resolves without dealing battle damage.

Attack Procedure

Declaration Step

The active player declares one or more eligible creatures they control as attacking creatures.

At this point, the declared creature(s) are considered to be **attacking** or **attacks** or have **attacked**.

The active player declares exactly one legal target for that attack.

A creature on the opponent's field.

At this point, the target creature is considered to have been **attacked**.

Opponents hand, only if there are no other legal targets.

The attacking creature(s) and the attacked creature go to the battle zone. (You don't have to move the cards to some battle zone; this zone can be inferred.)

After the attack is declared, the Attackers and the Target cannot change, other than by card ability/effect.

Battle Step

If the target is a creature, battle damage is dealt simultaneously as follows:

One attacking creature vs. one target creature:

The attacking creature deals damage equal to its current ATK to the target creature.

At the same time, the target creature deals damage equal to its current ATK to the attacking creature.

Two or more attacking creatures vs. one target creature:

Add together the current ATK of all attacking creatures. That total is dealt to the target creature.

At the same time, the target creature deals damage equal to its current ATK to *each* attacking creature *individually*.

If the target creature leaves the field before battle damage is dealt, the attack still resolves, but no creature is dealt battle damage. All creatures declared as attackers are still considered to have attacked.

If the target is the opponent's hand, the attack is considered a **Direct Attack**. Add together the current ATK of all attacking creatures. The defending player takes that much damage and discards that many cards from their hand. If that player has fewer cards in hand than the damage amount, they discard all cards remaining in their hand and lose.

A Direct Attack *does* place the hand in the battle zone. This does not mean any creatures or spells in the hand are considered to be in battle. When your hand is in battle, it is only considered X number of cards; what the cards are is irrelevant.

Damage dealt during one battle does not carry over to later battles or later turns.

Resolution Step

Any creature that was dealt damage equal to or greater than its DEF during battle is destroyed.

Destroyed creatures are sent to the **Discard Pile**.

Surviving creatures return to their previous field/go to their controller's field.

After the attack resolves, the active player may declare another attack, if able, or proceed to their next Phase.

Examples

Creature vs. Creature: If a 3 ATK / 1 DEF creature attacks a 3 ATK / 3 DEF creature, each deals damage to the other at the same time. Both creatures are dealt damage equal to or greater than their DEF, so both are destroyed and sent to their respective Discard Piles.

Multi Attack, 3 Creatures vs. 1 Creature: If two 1/1 creatures and a 2/3 creature attack a 2/4 target creature, the total damage dealt to the target is 1+1+2=4. Each attacking creature takes 2 damage (the ATK of the target). Both 1/1 attacking creatures and the 2/4 target creature are sent to their respective Discard Piles, and the attacking 2/3 creature survives and is sent back to the attacking player's field.

Direct Attack: If the opponent controls no creatures and two of your creatures with 2 ATK and 3 ATK attack the opponent's hand, that attack has 5 total ATK. The opponent discards 5 cards from their hand. If they had 5 cards in their hand, or fewer, they lose the game.

Miscellaneous Rules

This section explains important rules and clarifications that apply throughout the game, especially in situations not fully covered by other sections.

1. Rule Priority

Card abilities and effects may add to, change, or override any rule in this Rulebook. If a card's text conflicts with this Rulebook, follow the card's text.

A more specific rule takes precedence over a more general rule.

2. Playing and Resolving Cards and Effects

To play a card: pay its cost by discarding cards from your Hand equal to its cost, and declare it. The card is considered to now be played. Next, if the card is a creature, “on play” abilities would now take effect; if the card is a spell, the spell's effect would activate, and then the spell would resolve.

Once a cost is paid, it cannot be refunded.

A spell that resolves, is negated, or otherwise finishes resolving is put into its owner's Discard Pile.

At Will spells may be played whenever their written timing or trigger condition is satisfied, including during combat or another player's turn if so printed.

After any action is declared (such as playing a card, declaring an attack, or activating an ability), both players are given an opportunity to respond with At Will spells or valid abilities before that action resolves. The player who did not declare the action holds priority and responds first.

If multiple cards are played at the same point of the game, they resolve one at a time in reverse order of play, with the most recently played spell resolving first.

Example: Player A attacks with a creature. Player B plays an At Will spell to destroy the attacking creature. Player A responds with an At Will spell to negate Player B's spell. The actions resolve in reverse order: First, Player A's negation spell resolves, negating Player B's spell. Player B's spell is negated, so it is put into the Discard Pile without effect. Then, Player A's spell is also put into the Discard Pile. The attack then proceeds as normal.

If a spell or ability has no legal targets when it would resolve, it does nothing and resolves.

3. Simultaneous Events

If multiple effects controlled by the same player would resolve at the same time, that player chooses their order.

If effects controlled by different players would resolve at the same time, the active player's effects resolve first in an order chosen by the active player, then the non-active player's effects resolve in an order chosen by the non-active player.

If multiple players would lose the game at the same time, the game is a draw.

4. Illegal Actions and Rewinds

If an illegal action is discovered immediately, return the game to the most recent legal state, provided this can be done without guessing about changed hidden information.

If a full rewind is not possible, undo as much of the illegal action as can be clearly undone, leave the remaining game state as it is, and continue from the closest legal game state.

6. Loops and Repeated Actions

If the game enters a loop of only mandatory actions that do not result in a victory/defeat, and no player can make a different legal choice to end it, the game is a draw.

If a loop contains one or more optional actions, the player making the optional choice must choose a number of repetitions and then make a different legal choice, if possible, so the game can continue.

7. Additional Clarifications

Damage does not last between battles; however, damage dealt during an attack (like during the declaration phase) lasts the whole attack.

If a player must draw more cards than remain in their Deck, that player draws as many cards as possible. A player does not lose the game for having an empty Deck.

If a target becomes illegal before a spell or ability resolves, that spell or ability does not affect that target. If all of its targets are illegal when it would resolve, it does nothing and resolves.

If a card instructs a player to do something impossible, do as much as possible and ignore the impossible portion.

Players can always respond to an action if a card or ability allows them to.

Keyword Definitions

This page is the official glossary for specialized HandBound rules terms. If a card or rule uses one of the terms below as rule shorthand, use the definition on this page.

Active Player: The player whose turn it is.

Non-Active Player: The player who is not currently taking their turn.

Play / Played: To use a card from your hand by paying its cost. (This includes 0 cost cards)

Base ATK / Base DEF: The original Attack or Defense value printed on a creature card. If a card uses a variable value such as X or Y, its *own* text determines that base value.

Current ATK / Current DEF: The ATK or DEF a creature has at the moment.

Target / Targeted: The thing chosen to be affected by an attack, spell, or ability.

Direct Attack: A legal attack where the opponent's hand is the target.

Damage: Harm dealt to a hand or creatures DEF by an attack, ability, or effect.

Destroy / Destroyed: A creature that is removed from the field because it was dealt damage more than or equal to its DEF, or because an effect or ability said to destroy it.

Destroyed as a result of battle: A creature that is destroyed *during* battle. This could be because of damage from a creature's ATK or an ability/card effect that happened during a battle.

Negated / Negated: A spell card does not carry out its effect, resolves, and is sent to the Discard Pile.

Discard: To move a card from your hand to the Discard Pile.

Exile / Exiled: To remove a card from the game to Exile.

Resolve / Resolves: To finish carrying out the effect of a spell, ability, or game action. (Card effects and abilities can resolve while doing nothing)

Trigger / Triggered: A stated event or condition that causes an ability or timing permission to apply.